

km from Patna, Muhachak Jamsaut, where Devi lives, is an apology of a village where nothing grows. Fifty odd Mushar families—a landless community of Dalits—live here, working mostly as unskilled labourers. NREGS, the UPA Government's flagship scheme, provides a legal guarantee for 100 days of employment a year, consisting of unskilled manual work, to adult members of a rural household. Work under NREGS includes water conservation, land development, rural road building and any other activity approved by the Ministry of Rural Development. The scheme has touched the lives of Muhachak villagers only partially. Even though they have been provided with pucca Indira Awas units, many of which are dilapidated, the villagers'

WATER WORKS: A tunnel project underway in Mumbai

lives are not much better than before. Education is not a priority and children are made to do petty work. NREGS workers here are paid Rs 75 a day although the rules provide for Rs 82. Villagers have not heard of unemployment allowance that they are eligible to get in case the Government is unable to provide work to those who seek it. According to Bihar Rural Development Minister Vaidhyanath Prasad Mahto, job cards have been provided to 70.37 lakh households in the state. "Of this, 27.74 lakh have demanded work, while we have managed to provide jobs to 27.73 lakh people. As many as 30,317 work schemes have been completed under NREGS," he claims. But in Muhachak alone, though there are 500 job card holders, over half have been waiting for work for over two months.

by Amitabh Srivastava

CORE SCORES

Mumbai, Maharashtra

JAWAHARLAL NEHRU NATIONAL URBAN RENEWAL MISSION

Budget allocation for 2008-09

Rs 6,866 crore

DISTINCTION	PASS	FAIL

The Jawaharlal Nehru National Urban Renewal Mission (JNNURM) is the first concerted effort since independence to improve the infrastructure and quality of life in India's urban areas. The mission seeks to improve infrastructure in cities like Mumbai where housing is crumbling, mass urban transport networks are creaking and water and sewage disposal facilities belong to

MANDAR DEODHAR

